



The Tragic Tale of the Great Auk: From Extinction to Conservation

【BBC Ideas 最后的巨海雀：一个物种的灭绝如何唤醒人类对第六次大灭绝的反思 | 从个体行动到全球协议 | 保护生物多样性的未来】

Summary: The story of the great auk's extinction in the 19th century marked a turning point in human understanding of species loss. Once abundant in the North Atlantic, these flightless birds were hunted to extinction by sailors for meat, feathers, and scientific collection. Georges Cuvier's theory of extinction, initially applied to mastodons, later highlighted humanity's role in driving species to extinction. Today, human activities like intensive farming, fossil fuel burning, and urbanization are accelerating biodiversity loss, pushing over a million species toward extinction. However, global agreements and individual actions, such as Hotlin's dentistry-based conservation in Borneo, offer hope for reversing this crisis.

摘要：19世纪巨海雀的灭绝标志着人类对物种消失认识的转折点。这种不会飞的海鸟曾在大西洋北部繁衍生息，却因水手捕猎其肉、羽毛和科学收藏而灭绝。乔治·居维叶的灭绝理论最初应用于猛犸象，后来揭示了人类在物种灭绝中的直接作用。如今，集约农业、化石燃料燃烧和城市化正加速生物多样性丧失，使超过百万物种濒临灭绝。但全球协议（如2030年保护30%地球的承诺）和个体行动（如印尼牙医通过医疗援助换森林保护）为逆转危机带来了希望。





🕒 Estimated Reading Time: 7 min.

📖 四级生词 📖 六级生词 📖 雅思生词 📖 托福生词 📖 专八生词 📖 SAT生词 📖 考研生词 📖 GRE生词 📖 其它生词

🎵 00:00:00

🎵 The story of the last great orc is a tragic tale, but one worth telling.

最后一只大海雀的故事是一个悲剧，但也是一个值得讲述的故事。

🎵 A gentle, flightless seabird, it once thrived on the windswept islands of the North Atlantic, but it was hunted for its meat, collectible eggs, feathers and oil.

它是一种温顺的、不会飞的海鸟，曾经在北大西洋那些狂风肆虐的岛屿上繁衍生息，但人们为了它的肉、可收藏的蛋、羽毛和油而猎杀它。

🎵 Its population declined rapidly in the 19th century.

它的数量在19世纪迅速下降。

⏮ Unused to any kind of predator, enormous numbers were captured.

由于不习惯任何捕食者，大量的海雀被捕获。

⏮ 00:00:24

⏮ The islands on which the orcs lived became fast food drive-thrus for European sailors traveling to the new world.

海雀居住的岛屿成了前往新世界的欧洲水手们的快餐“免下车”餐厅。

⏮ In 1844, the last known pair of great orcs were found on Elde Island off the coast of Iceland.

1844年，最后一对已知的大海雀在冰岛海岸外的埃尔德岛上被发现。

⏮ A group of sailors captured the placid birds.

一群水手捕获了这些温顺的鸟。

⏮ Tragically, the last pair were killed not for food, but for scientific curiosity and collection.

可悲的是，最后一对大海雀被杀不是为了食物，而是为了科学好奇心和收藏。

⏮ 00:00:47

⏮ For much of Western European history, many people, including scientists, believed that nature's creations were eternal or protected by God.

在西欧历史的大部分时间里，包括科学家在内的许多人都认为自然界的造物是永恒的或受到上帝保护的。

⏮ In 1796, scientists Georges Cuvier put forward a new theory.

1796年，科学家乔治·居维叶提出了一个新理论。

⏮ By studying fossils of ancient elephants called mastodons, he proved that some species could completely die out.

通过研究一种叫做乳齿象的古象化石，他证明了一些物种可能会完全灭绝。

🎵 Cuvier thought natural disasters had killed the mastodons.

居维叶认为是自然灾害杀死了乳齿象。

🎵 But it wasn't until humans hunted the great orc to extinction around 50 years later that people realized that human action could directly cause a species extinction and forever reshape the natural world.

但直到大约50年后人类将大海雀猎杀至灭绝，人们才意识到人类行为可以直接导致一个物种的灭绝，并永远重塑自然世界。

🎵 Scientists have now identified five periods of mass extinction where species have been eradicated at alarming speed.

科学家们现在已经确定了五个物种以惊人速度被消灭的大灭绝时期。

🎵 Previously, these mastigoths had natural causes like volcanic activity and the asteroid that wiped out dinosaurs 66 million years ago.

以前，这些大灭绝是由自然原因造成的，比如火山活动和6600万年前消灭恐龙的小行星。

🎵 Normally, a new or existing species fills the gap.

通常，一个新的或现有的物种会填补这个空白。

🎵 But today, life on Earth is vanishing faster than it can be replaced.

但今天，地球上的生命正在以比其被替代更快的速度消失。

🎵 Intensive farming has transformed the planet.

集约化农业改变了地球。

🎵 The burning of fossil fuels has caused catastrophic climate change and sprawling cities have paved over habitats.

化石燃料的燃烧导致了灾难性的气候变化，而不断扩张的城市则铺平了栖息地。

⌂ Human activity has driven flora and fauna into smaller and smaller spaces and reduced them to smaller and smaller numbers.

人类活动已将动植物驱赶到越来越小的空间，并使它们的数量越来越少。

⌂ There are thought to be over a million species on the brink of extinction globally.

据认为，全球有超过一百万种物种濒临灭绝。

⌂ Take the humble hedgehog, expanding cities and shrinking hedge roads, toxic pesticides and busy roads are driving our prickly friends to the brink.

以不起眼的刺猬为例，城市的扩张和树篱小路的减少、有毒杀虫剂和繁忙的道路正将我们这些带刺的朋友推向灭绝的边缘。

bilibili 00:02:29

⌂ Three-quarters of Britain's rural hedge loving hogs have disappeared in the last couple of decades.

在过去的几十年里，英国四分之三喜爱树篱的乡村刺猬已经消失了。

⌂ And it's not just hedgehogs, the loss of an iconic species signals a much deeper issue.

而且不仅仅是刺猬，一个标志性物种的丧失预示着一个更深层次的问题。

⌂ The collapse of entire ecosystems where countless creatures and plants depend on one another.

整个生态系统的崩溃，其中无数的生物和植物相互依存。

⌂ These ecosystems are vital to our survival, providing the pollination of our food, cleaning our air and water and protecting us from floods and droughts.

这些生态系统对我们的生存至关重要，它们为我们的食物授粉，清洁我们的空气和水，并保护我们免受洪水和干旱的侵害。

bilibili 00:02:59

⌂ Since we are the cause of this sixth mass extinction, we can also be the solution.

既然我们是这第六次大灭绝的起因，我们也可以成为解决方案。

▶ In 2022, nations across the world agreed to reverse biodiversity loss and protect 30% of our planet by the end of the decade.

2022年，世界各国同意扭转生物多样性丧失的趋势，并在本十年末保护我们星球30%的陆地和海洋。

▶ Achieving the target would certainly slow by diversity loss, but arguably it will take a far greater effort from governments, businesses and individuals working together to transform our relationship with nature and prevent mass extinction.

实现这一目标当然会减缓生物多样性的丧失，但可以说，这需要政府、企业和个人付出更大的努力，共同努力改变我们与自然的关系，防止大规模灭绝。

bilibili 00:03:32

▶ And sometimes individuals can have a big impact.

有时个人也能产生巨大的影响。

▶ Hotlin on Pousongu is a dentist who lives in Indonesian Borneo.

霍特琳·昂·普桑古是一位住在印度尼西亚婆罗洲的牙医。

▶ This Asian island is covered in some of the most incredible rainforest and is home to hornbills, lapids and orangutans.

这个亚洲岛屿覆盖着一些最不可思议的热带雨林，是犀鸟、懒猴和猩猩的家园。

▶ Slowly swinging through the rainforest with their long arms, orangutans have been driven to near extinction, in part because of rapid deforestation.

猩猩用它们的长臂在雨林中缓慢摆荡，它们已被逼至濒临灭绝，部分原因是快速的森林砍伐。

bilibili 00:04:00

▶ Hotlin knew that poor health and poverty incentivized local people to chop trees to pay for treatment.

霍特琳知道，健康不佳和贫困促使当地人砍树来支付治疗费用。

▶ So, Hotlin offered discounted dentistry to anyone who didn't cut down the forest.

所以，霍特琳向任何不砍伐森林的人提供折扣牙科服务。

▶ If anyone couldn't afford treatment, they could plant native trees or learn how to earn an income from organic farming.

如果有人负担不起治疗费用，他们可以种植本地树木，或学习如何通过有机农业赚取收入。

▶ Since she started in 2011, over 100,000 trees have been planted and illegal logging in her area has been significantly reduced, improving and protecting the orangutans habitat.

自她2011年开始这项工作以来，已种植了超过10万棵树，她所在地区的非法采伐已显著减少，从而改善和保护了猩猩的栖息地。

 00:04:35

▶ These charismatic creatures are now beginning to come back in numbers, thanks in part, to Hotlin.

这些有魅力的生物现在开始大量回归，部分要感谢霍特琳。

▶ Extinction isn't just about far off exotic creatures.

灭绝不仅仅关乎遥远的异域生物。

▶ It's happening in our backyards too, but unlike the great orc, the fate of the hedgehog and countless other species can still be changed.

它也正发生在我们的后院，但与大海雀不同，刺猬和无数其他物种的命运仍然可以改变。

▶ The extinction crisis we're facing isn't just about animals and plants, it's about the future of all life on earth, including us.

我们面临的灭绝危机不仅仅关乎动植物，它关乎地球上所有生命的未来，包括我们。

 00:05:04

▶ Individuals can only do so much.

个人的力量是有限的。

▶ Will we work together to stop driving the sixth mass extinction?

我们会共同努力来阻止第六次大灭绝吗？

